



SANDEEP SAXENA

his father here, Lakshya ruled out any change in the immediate future. “I don’t think there are any major changes needed to be made. A lot of good things also happened throughout the year, and some that I can surely improve, so I just need to continue focusing on them while planning ahead. No big changes are planned; just trying to continue good training and improve in every way. The process is to be a better player all the time, and that will continue,” he said when asked about any possible change in his coaching team.

Syed Modi was a tale of contrasts. Sindhu grew in confidence and performance with each match, rediscovering her love for the game and staying positive throughout, often smiling and sharing her insights. Lakshya, meanwhile, was all business—focused, efficient, and

reserved. He dominated his matches with minimal interaction, showing only a brief smile after the final as his sole expression of emotion.

It was in the doubles that the Indians truly had a chance to prove themselves, and they duly obliged, none more than the 21-year-olds Treesa and Gayatri (pic, above). As the only Indians to have qualified for the Tour Finals, the duo has already proven it is in for the long haul. In Lucknow, the two showed how much they had put in to reach this level over the last few years. “We just wanted to win very badly and kept moving, kept fighting,” they said after winning the final.

That desperation to win was visible on the court too. Despite being stretched to hour-long, three-game matches multiple times, the pair kept finding more in the tank

to stay in the hunt and sustain every day all through the week. With every match, various areas of their gameplay kept getting highlighted — if it was the precision of drops in one, it was the rock-solid defence in another, and the ability to dig deep for power at others. Clearly, the youngsters are marked for greater heights.

However, the men’s and the mixed doubles remain a concern. While Dhruv Kapila and Tanisha Crasto managed to show glimpses of possible growth as a pair in their second-place finish, the absence of a genuine successor to Sat-Chi was clearly felt among the men. But in a year that had too many lows and sparingly few highs, Indian badminton fans will take all they can get. Fingers crossed for a better 2025.